Nobody can do it like a steam!

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Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Heritage Railway, Steam locomotives, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, How to drive a train, Minor Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Minor Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), glitra, POV Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), glimmer is a brat, Scorpia is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Minor Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by the_Frank

Summary

Who would have thought that Catra would find her place in life at the footplate of a steam engine? Who would have thought that shoveling coal into a hungry engine would give a troubled teen the path in life she needed? Definitely not Catra! But here she is! A little heritage railway in the dark woods of Småland is her life, her love, her everything!

Until the day she gets a trainee, someone to go along with her to learn the secrets of the steam engine... That would have been well and good hadn't it been for the fact that this... GLIMMER-GIRL... wears a pink ovearall, has pink hair and is... just SO DAMN ANNOYING! So what if Catra is rude to her, it's not like Glimmer likes her anyway!

Or does she?

Be prepared for a bumpy road to love! Get ready for some really greasy, oily and messy romance on the footplate! See the tension rising with the pressure and hear the song of love played out by the whistle of the mighte steam engine!
The Glitra-Heritage railway-AU absolutely NO ONE asked for. But here it is. Enjoy.

To Lisra, for inspiring me to write a nordic AU.
And to Randomisedmongoose for writing about steam engines before I dared to.
And yes, the title IS from Starlight Express.

Notes

To one of the best persons in the world. Happy Birthday, Angie.

See the end of the work for more notes

Nobody can do it like a steam

By

The Frank.

It was a beautiful morning in the engine shed at Norraryd. The view over the Hönshylte Fiord was beautiful in the rays of the rising sun but it was still rather quiet and still. Only a few birds could be heard and she had seen a row of ducks passing over the road heading for the Hönshylte Meer.

Yes, it *should* be a great day, already! Even at this ungodly hour. In theory at least, because Catra had yet to get her first cup of coffee. It is funny, that. Non-coffee drinkers would never understand how the world turned brighter, the sky got a hint bluer and everything - yes everything… seemed possible, after that first cup of coffee. But on the other hand, there were a lot of things people didn't understand. Why you would pay money to get yourself dirty for one.

Catra looked down on her smudgy paws. And smudgier they would get. But alas, she sighed and looked back through the open gates to the subject inside the shed. She smiled a little. No coffee until her lady had been served. Catra wiped some sweat from her brow and went back to work. The rising sun came with a rising temperature and she would gladly take the coolness of the engine shed for a few hours more before it was time to get sweaty for real! Her lady was demanding, but she would reward hard work.

Her lady was not an ordinary lady, no. She was a 50 ton 2-8-0 Gt-class narrow gauge steam engine, built in 1949, bearing the number 4048. Generally referred to as "old 4-8", Catra called her *Brünhilde.* Not that there was anything particularly German about her, she was a proud product of the Motala Works. But it was just the feeling Catra had gotten the first time her eyes fell on her, as she pulled out of the station in Norraryd, pulling along 5 passenger cars filled with happy tourists. At the moment she was

Catras' favourite lady, and from time to time it felt like the only lady she needed in her life.

It had been, what was it, seven years ago, when she first found the little heritage railway in the darkest of Småland. Back then she had been a quiet and slightly emo kid who had been forced to join the family road trip. It had been a dud (because everything was then, the world was shit, no girl appriciated her, Mums' were stupid etc…), save for the visit to Norraryd and the train ride… Catra had returned, more and more. She had found a few friends, but more than anything she had found her call, the thing that took her through the long and lonely winter nights. The joy of working on a steam locomotive. (The other units didn't count.) Two years ago Catra herself had finally managed to build up enough courage to start her own training program and now she was a fireman on the Norraryd - Kvarnamåla Heritage railway. There were a few more steam engines to serve on, but the times Catra was on duty with *Brünhilde* were the best. …Unfortunately that meant getting up early as shit, to drive the 38.8 miles from her apartment in Växjö to Norraryd. And she had to get there waaaay too early. It took around 4-5 hours to get her lady prepared for service. It was worth it, by the end of the day! At 6.30 a.m? Not that much. (These were the times she was the most happy she was single. Imagine trying to get up and out not waking someone up.) Catra had started the day by first binding up her tail (The treacherous thing had a tendency to get in the way), cover her ears and mane with a cap and then climb into her overalls. Oil in fur was not easy to clean and she was not making *that* mistake ever again. She had just finished cleaning out the firebox and the ashbox when Scorpia arrived. Early.

Scorpia had been the one who had reeled Catra in, taking the shy and grumpy (And even outright hostile) teenager in the gentle grip of her pincers(Litterally! Scorpia was a hugger....), and gently prodding her into a full-blown train nerd. There were moments when Catra suspected Scorpia having a crush on her… but she threw those feelings away, since Scorpia had introduced her wife

Perfuma within the first five days they met, and she didn't seem like someone who went around. (Was that sad? Maybe a little…) And that was the end of that. Catra shoved the memories away and smirked at Scorpia.

"Gomorron Scorp. Ready for another day of toil and sweat?"

"Det vet du, wildcat! Time to get them muscles working and the steam on top! And the… ehm… Yeah." Catras smirk widened.

"You said it. Who's on service today? I forgot to check the list." Scorpia the list nerd made a thoughtful face.

"Well, I am on the engine with you of course.. Bow is station master here, Mista is in charge of Urshult, and… Drats, I can't remember who's on the railbus, but Frosta is our train master. Oh! And you are having a trainee today!"

Catra sighed. Not a damn trainee! Not that she wasn't in favour of the trainee system, that was the best way to learn how to treat her ladies (Along with old 4-8, the heritage trust owned another three steam engines, along with two diesel shunters, one diesel *engine* , two railbuses with trailers and more goods carriages than Catra bothered to count.) but… They took so damn LONG to GET IT! and not only that, some were just not cut for it. Unfortunately, she was not allowed to tell them that. Not since the 'incident' with Kyle. Apparently it was bad PR to send someone home screaming and crying. On the other hand, he was NOT made for the footplate. He was better suited for the railbus, and eventually he had accepted his fate.

In a way, Catra admired him, she would never put her paws on *those* controls. Oil-powered motors came from the Diesel himself. Nope, she generously handed those over to Lonnie, Kyle and Roge. And all of the other disieselrs. She followed her sigh with a groan.

"Come on Scorp! Not today!"

"Catra…"

“No! Don’t give me that look! I don’t want a trainee! I can’t handle them! They annoy me and hinder me from making a perfect fire.”

Scorpia was also the director, and Catra should know better than to challenge her authority. But she really wasn’t in the mood. Damn it all, if she’d just had her coffee…

A shadow of anger passed over Scorpias face, and then she said “No coffee yet?”

Catra didn’t answer. Scorpia put her pincer on her shoulder. Not very gently this time.

“Look, Cat. We all know that trainees can be a bit of a handful at times, but come on! We were all beginners at some time! And without new blood, who will drive “Brünhilde” in the future?”

“Me and you. I will not let go of that shovel until I fall down dead on the footplate.”

Scorpia rolled her eyes, and grabbed Catra in her pincers, lifting her up, so that they were eye to eye.

“Get that coffee. And pick up your trainee. She is in the crew room.”

Catra glared at her. “Unfair advantage of body size, Scorp..”

“I know. I only use my powers with great responsibility. Now go get her, tiger.”

The walk from the engine shed to the Crew room was short, but since it was early, most of the station was empty and devoid of people. But during that short walk, Catras' mood had not improved. She had a tendency to assume the worst, especially when faced with shit she wasn’t warned about before. And she went through all the clumsy asses she had tried her best to coach.

One who never learned how to use the injector. One who couldn't separate back and front. One who always used too much coal and one who always whistled the intro to "Thomas the tank engine."

To be fair, Sam had turned out to be a pretty good fireman but… It took a while.

Let's just hope it's not a total… mess… and… vad i helvete…
Entering she was greeted with three sights, two that pleased her and one that… well.

There was freshly made coffee. And there was a basket filled with sandwiches. Catra suspected Perfuma being responsible, she was always bugging Scorpia for not eating properly when in service.

And then there was the woman.

Pink.

A fucking PINK overall.

PINK fucking safety boots. PINK gloves. She did wear a black cap but…

Catra turned on the spot, and didn't even answer the "You must be Cat…ra…" that this…thing… greeted her with. She marched right back to the shed and the second she saw Scorpia she yelled. "VAFAN, Scorpia! I am NOT doing this!"

"Catra…"

"NO! NO NO NO NO! She wears fucking PINK! PINK! I helvete att..I am NOT letting someone wearing PINK to serve Brünhilde! NEVER!"

"Catra…"

"NO! I refuse! That is a person who doesn't care! She doesn't care SQUAT about trains! She is just here because she thinks it's 'rustic chic' or something! Someone who will stop every fifth second to

make sure her NAILS are safe." She paused to take a breath. "If you want her in, YOU take her. *I* refuse."

Suddenly Scorpia stood there, towering over her with that hint of darkness back in her eyes. Catra had to swallow, it was such a rare thing to see Scorpia angry that she almost took two steps back. Alright, not *angry.* But *disappointed.* And that was probably worse… She spoke, with a calm voice, but with emphasis on a few significant things.

"Katarina. I suggested you because you are a really really good fireman. I also kiiinda expected you to be mature about this. YOU of all people judging someone by their looks? *Really?"*

"...The overall's brand new, Scorp… I know what it costs and…"

"I know what it costs as well, Katarina. I got one. The grey one. So, that's the deal? She's rich?"

"...It's just a fad for her, Scorp. I am sure."

"You don't get to Scorp me right now, Katarina. *Sofia, please and thank you* , and if you keep going it's Chairman Dröm."

Catra shrunk in her boots. Then she felt Scorpias heavy pincer on her shoulder again.

"Catra. Come on. Shall I remind you about how a certain wildcat looked the first time she came in for a training session? The leather jacket, the *torn* jeans? The *green sneakers?* How your tail almost got stuck in the rods? Come on! At least she is wearing something practical and suitable! And what did you wear the second time, when I told you that sneakers wasn't the best choice?"

Catra didn't answer.

"Clogs, Catra. Clogs. Clogs and a two number to large sweatshirt. You can't wear anything worse, save for a silk dress. However. Did I stop you?"

"...No."

"And why did I not stop you? Because I realized that this was a girl who had heard a few No's to many. I let you work in that outfit as well, and at the end of the day, you had reached the conclusion yourself that you should get proper boots."

"Mmm."

"Look at me, Wildcat."

Catra did, the anger in Scorpias eyes was almost on its way to pass. But not completely.

"You can be grumpy. You can have a bad day. You don't have to be overfriendly, no one who knows you expects you to. But you CAN be polite, and you DON'T get to scare off another potential member."

Catra looked away. "...mkay."

"Good! And…he he… Sorry about that. I don't like it when I have to chairman someone, I really don't!" Now the cloud was gone and overpositive Scorpia was back. "Besides, maybe you will find a new best friend? Off you go, get us a new star fireman!"

Grinding her teeth, Catra walked out of the shed.

*

Inside the crew room, the mood was…unstable. Glimmer sat with her coffee in hand, a single sip had yet to be taken, while Bow and Perfuma (who had joined them when she heard loud voices) had almost finished theirs. However, they had not talked as much as Glimmer had. The crew room was not a good room to be angry in. It was small, dimly lit and very very brown. Just a few photos

of old trains on the walls, a few tables, a coffee maker, a microwave and a fridge. It was a place where you took a quick break, maybe had a discussion about the good old days when the trains on the line ran regularly? But it was not a place to be angry because the atmosphere just did everything worse.

Bow listened with half an ear. He had been a member since he was 14, and had known Glimmer for even longer. But she had not shown any interest until recently, and even if he was a bit hesitant, he *had* been the one who had convinced Glimmer to join the railway foundation, and to actually trying out the volunteer work. However, he also had suggested for her to start off easy, with being a conductor, or maybe trying her hand with getting the website in order. That had been thrown out the window the second Glimmer had seen the Old 4-8 run past them outside Urshult at full speed and with a smiling Adora at the levers. After that, all Glimmer could talk about was to be a fireman. Alright, that was good and all, but perhaps not something for the absolute beginner? Even at age 24, it was a challenge. He himself had tried a few times, but he and the steam engines had separated amiably. Ah well, it was Glimmer. She was not one to accept a No easily.

"...And I can only wonder what is wrong with me! I have the clothes, I have the right attitude! And this… this bitch just looks at me and turns around! What kind of attitude is that?"

"She was probably just surprised, that is all." Perfuma tried her best to calm Glimmer down. That was usually Bow's job, best friend and all. But today was one of those rare days when Glimmer went on his nerves, because there is only that much Glimmer you can take before the cup is filled. It didn't help that he was having doubts on exactly how prepared she was, new outfit not counting. So today, Perfuma was welcome to handle Glimmer.

"It is rather early in the morning and, well, to be fair, Scorpia didn't tell me that you would be here until we drove over here. You are more than welcome of course, but it's because of that I always make three extra sandwiches. My dear partner sometimes forgets that communication is key, and Catra needs some time to adjust. I assure you that things will be just fine once she gets her coffee."

Bow got a slightly worried look in his eyes. Crap. Was she going to train alongside *Catra?* Not that he didn't like Catra! She was pretty fun and she was a skilled fireman (and almost driver, just a few times with a coach and she was ready!) But she could be… a lot. And unfortunately, so could Glimmer. And two a-lot-people can't occupy the same space at the same time. Okay. So maybe this actually needed his full attention!

"Glimmer, just calm down. Nothing gets better with you being angry. I agree with Perfuma, Catra was probably just surprised to see you." Glimmer snorted.

"Pah! You did not see the look! It was not surprice, it was *pure. disgust!* Am I *really* that despicable, Bow? I am a good looking woman! Both of you can vouch for that! You don't look at a good looking woman with disgust! …I bet she's biphobic."

"Catra? No no, she…"

"AND! I have muscles! I work out, I run… sometimes. I *look hot!* She was, what? Thin like a plank! If that bitch can do it, so can I! Easy-peasy!"

Bow opened his mouth when he noticed how Perfuma's eyes were drawn to the door, and he soon followed along.

Oh crap.

Catra stood in the doorway and it was obvious that she had heard more or less everything that Glimmer had said. Giving them all a death glare, she helped herself to a cup of coffee and emptied it

in one go. That did make Glimmer raise a few eyebrows. Then she had another one, and then she pointed to Glimmer.

“Alright, Pinky. You want to go on that footplate, you got to earn your place. Finish that cup and come with me. We are running late and we have a shitload of things to do before departure.”

“I *do* have a name.”

“So do I, doesn’t mean I let anyone use it. Today your ass is mine and your name is pinky. Now come along or run home to mommy. The engine waits for no one.”

And then she grabbed a sandwich. “Oh, and just so you know it? I’m queer. But you are simply not my type.” And then she left. Glimmer looked at the others for support, but in the end she slowly left the room in the direction that Catra had gone.

Bow looked at the door, then at Perfuma.

“Scorpia didn’t warn her?”

“No. She ‘didn’t think it would be a problem’” Perfuma took a deep relaxing breath. “ You tried to get Glimmer not to buy a pink overall?”

“Tried. Yes.”

Perfuma nodded.

“We love our friends, right?”

“We love our friends.”

"And our SO’s.”

“Yes.”

“...Will you talk to Catra once this is over?”

“Yeah. You take Glimmer?”

“I can try.”

*

Glimmer had decided two things from the very moment she left the crew room. She did not like Catra and she was not going to budge. The sun had risen and it was a beautiful day indeed. Over the fiord she could see the woodland and the bushes and small trees surrounding the workshop slowly moving in the gentle wind. And on the road next to them, the summer traffic had begun. That wasn’t exactly beautiful, that only increased Glimmer's bad mood. It reminded her that her car was at the shop and that she had to take the bus…

Now, one hour later, she had cemented that first statement and begun to doubt the second. Catra had not been cutting her any slack. The first thing she got her to do was to clean the firebox from slag and then the ashpan hopper from ash AND slag. When Glimmer remarked that they looked clean enough Catra had just glared and said “If you don’t want to learn this properly, by all means. The gate is open and in that direction.” So cleaned she had. After that, she had to fetch the oil canteen and the oil gun. And then there was around fifty places or something that required lubrication. And Catra argued with her everytime that she did something wrong. Either it was to much or too little or the wrong place. And then it was time to carry firewood. Lots of firewood. *LOTS* of it. Glimmer did protest once and said “Isn’t this thing supposed to run on coal?”

Catra had given her a new death glare. “It’s not a ‘thing’. It’s an *engine* and SHE would slap you if she heard you talk about her that way. And yes, but that is when we run trains when we fire her up we use wood. Out there we burn money. In here? We burn sweat. Get another load, and then get your ass in the cab. It’s time to fire her up.”

Once Glimmer had unloaded the last piece of wood in the doorway, she climbed inside.

“Alright pinky. What do we do now?”

“...Light a match?”

“Really.”

“...Yes, really?”

“Do you know what a dryout is, pinky? Risk a firebox collapse due to low water levels?”

“...no?”

“Figures. That’s what happens when you put the fire on when there's no water in the boiler. It will destroy the whole engine. Do you want to do that to this nice lady, Pinky?”

“N-no…”

“GOOD! So what do we do first?”

“...Check the water levels?”

“One point for you, Pinks. And where do we do that?”

Glimmer looked around until she noticed two glass tubes mounted on the center of the boiler. They seemed empty but there was a hint of a line in one of them…”

“There?” She said and pointed.

“Huh. Damn. You got that one right. Yes, that is the water gauge. Remember that, because that is where 80% of our attention must be. And do we have enough water?”

“...No?”

This time Catra smiled. A predatory, evil smile. “Correct, pinky! And do you know how we fix that?”

Turns out that meant going out on the running board with the largest monkey wrench Glimmer had seen, unscrewing a valve and putting a water hose straight into the boiler. The valve plug had been stuck good, and it had taken her some good five minutes to loosen it. And then the water hose had been leaking. Meaning that now not only was she sweaty, but also wet. After the plug was put back in, she went inside the cab, where Catra was waiting. “Alright. Now to make a fire.”

When she didn’t move, Glimmer took a piece of wood in her hand, earning a “tsk tsk tsk” from Catra. She took the piece and then said to Glimmer “Go and take a break. This is waaaay too advanced for you. Come back in 45 and we will get the cylinder oil refilled.”

Glimmer sat in the crew room, all alone. Bow was busy with his business, and she didn’t feel like complaining to him anyway. And Perfuma felt like she would be on Cat-bitchs side.

The worst part was that Glimmer kinda admired Catra. She had seen her a few times in the cab, looking out of the windows and letting the wind play with her hair. She had looked so cool, so tough, so in control so hot. She had not known her name, but for a second she had felt happiness when she learned who her coach would be.

For exactly one second…

That woman is not a cat. She's a demon. or a devil. Or a devildemon. But when you smell like coal and brimstone, you probably have to.

Through the window she could see the engine shed in the distance. The smoke had begun to rise from the chimney, so Glimmer braced herself from the next attack from Catra.

It came five minutes later.

"Well, princess. I hope you don't mind getting your precious nails dirty because now it is time… for the *thick* oil.

The thick oil was as sluggish as molasses, if not worse. And Catra had her refilling the cylinders, the air compressor for the breaks and finally the Wakefield Lubricator. It took ages, and she did get dirty nails. After that it was an endless cycle of carrying wood, feeding the fire, and getting chewed out by Catra.

First Catra complained that Glimmer hadn't been there when she had lubricated the rods and gears up, and when Glimmer said that it was Catra that sent her away she had hissed at her. Then she forced her under the engine to put some oil in the axle boxes. And then she yelled at her for doing it wrong.

Glimmer actually felt relieved when Scorpia arrived, fully uniformed and with a big smile on her face, to take the engine out and then shunt it down to the carriages. That did dampen Catra a bit, and finally she had gone off to change her outfit. *Finally free from that shithead…*

Scorpia also showed her how the turntable worked and explained that even if they had one in Kvarnamåla, there was none in Tingsryd, so the Engine had to go in reverse on the way back. But that was not a problem. Glimmer asked what their maximum speed would be and got a little disappointed when Scorpia answered with 25 mph. "But" she added when she noticed Glimmer pouting, "The railbus touches 40. That's pretty fun."

Yeah. Glimmer had to agree, that was fun. But it wasn't a steam engine… And she really wanted to be on that steam engine. Although preferably far away from cat-turd. AAARGH!

The worst part was that Glimmer still admired her. A little. When she didn't yell, or glare…she actually looked pretty good. She did know her way around the engine and even if she never explained what she did, she got the impression that she was in total control. Glimmer could admire that. Would have admired that. Had Catra not been so awful with people.

Scorpia was nice, and even if she had to focus on making the engine move, she did throw some conversation at Glimmer. Wasn't it a nice day? Oh, I like your overalls! I got the same sort! Driving a steamer is such a rush! It's not the same as a car, it's… It's a living breathing thing!!

There was a honk on their left side as the yellow and orange railbus passed them, shunting down to the small yellow station building. And it WAS small, looking more like a shed than a house. Bow had explained to her that the original railway didn't have the best economy so the building here was as big as they could afford. The station at Urshult where the HQ had been was much bigger of course! The driver, a mustached man who sported a black bandana under his cap saluted them as he drove one. Glimmer knew Sea-Hawk, Bow's loverboy, of course. But she always forgot how he looked in a uniform. A few happy passengers had already arrived and boarded the bus, who soon ran away towards Kvarnamåla with a happy honk from the horn and a kiss blown from Bow to the driver. The sky was blue and the greenwood around the station building gave some much needed shadow and cooled things down quite a bit. The platform was getting filled with eager passengers of all ages and she could still hear the honks and hrududu from the receding railbus.

Maybe it was going to be a nice day after all?

Yeah, no.

*

Catras mood had not improved. Meeting Adora at the workshop had only soured it. Adora was, like Scorpia, always in a way to good mood, but Adora had a tendency to not let Catra rant but to offer her advice… Which had it's time and place but not *now* . So when she explained the problem with Glimmer to her, all she said was "Oh come on, Catra! She seems nice! I think you will work things out fine!"

She did NOT want anything akin to constructive advice. She wanted support in her annoyance with Glimmer and when she didn't get that…

Catra almost flipped the bird at a passing Entrapta, carrying whatever she was fiddling with this week, be it the oil pump for the shunting engines or a switch for the cross-tie maschine.

And the second she was back on the train and her eyes met Glimmers they both turned black.

Five minutes later, Bow raised his signal spade in the air, gave the signal for departure, Scorpia grabbed the lever for the whistle in her tail and answered with a short "WHOOOIII", and they were off.

The ride was … interesting. At first, Catra let Glimmer do nothing, merely looking out the window. She sighed and decided to at least enjoy the ride. The railway went pretty close to the fiord, but mixed the seaside view with dipping into the dark geen smalland woods. Suddenly they passed over a stream on a very large and cool old bridge before they returned to the woods. Soon a unguarded crossing appeared, and Scorpia said "Road clear?" After a moment of confusing Glimmer realized that she had to look out on her side since the boiler blocked the view and replied "Road…clear?" earning a nod from Scorpia. After that she began

to repeat signals and keep an eye on the unguarded crossings (Like the fireman should).

And Catra got angry. *Oh, you think you get it, do you…*

"Pinkie! You're in charge of the injector!" No explanation, nothing. Catra could see a wrinkle on Scorpias forehead, but she would not intervene. She respected the fact that the fireman was in charge of her trainee but she slowly shook her head, not that Catra noticed.. Glimmer looked puzzled at first, but she did manage to figure out what the injector was. She did not figure out how it worked, though, and more than once she filled the trackbed with either water or steam. As the closed in on Urshult, Scorpia had to use *her* injector to get some water into the boiler, but she said nothing.

"Not so easy as it looks, Pinkie?"

"Well, maybe if someone had bothered to show me how it *works* instead of being a rude twat, I *might* have gotten it!"

Catra's eyes had become slits as she grudgingly showed Glimmer how it worked and what it was used for (pumping water from the tender into the boiler), and rolling into Urshult, she actually got it working and the level in the sight glasses began to rise.

However, now Catra decided that Glimmer should try the shovel. And again, without any explanation. The railway to Kvarnamåla was, luckily, pretty flat, but there were a few ascensions, especially towards Rössmåla, where her inability with the shovel began to show. Catra had to take her place, and after a massive deposit, the pressure began to rise again, and the train kept moving forward.

After that, Glimmer and Catra exchanged exactly three words.

"Bitch."

“Prissy Cunt.”

Arriving at Kvarnamåla, there was a 15 minute break as the engine ran around the train, facing the other direction, and waiting for the railbus to arrive from Tingsryd. Once the coupling was done, Glimmer went for the station building, but was called back by Catra.

“And where are you going?”

“I am thirsty. If you haven’t noticed, it’s quite warm in here.”

“Yeah, no, idiot. An experienced fireman has a bottle of water ready. You’re job is to/”

Scorpia had not said anything for the whole ride, save for the occasional technical line “Freerolling” “Driving!” “Road clear!” “Avgång!”, but she *had* given Catra a glance more than once. And this apparently was where the line was drawn.

“Glimmer. Go have something to drink. The engine will survive until Tingsryd.”

“Scorp, I…”

"*Scorpia* , Katarina. And *I* am the driver, meaning that technically I am in charge. So let your trainee drink. But be quick, the railbus is here soon.”

Glimmer had much easier to obey Scorpia but when she returned, the mood in the cab had not risen.

“Sit down. Both of you. Now, Katarina. No, you be quiet.”

Only now did Catra notice Scorpias shivering lips. Scorpia took a deep breath…. And then she started to cry.

“I can’t do this! I can’t just handle all this negativity! We are supposed to be *friends!* At the very least *comrades!* And yes C-Catra, I *apologize* for not letting you know beforehand you would

have someone with you. I k-know that you are sensitive about that and I am *so so sorry!!!"* She paused to blow her nose and continued a tad bit calmer. "THAT SAID. *You* should know how to be at least civil! And Glimmer… You have been behaving very rude as well."

"WHAT?"

"Perfuma told me what you said in the crew room. Yes, Catra was equally rude to behave like that. But namecalling? You don't even know her!"

Glimmer looked like she was going to argue, but Scorpia cut her off.

"This has gone too far. Katarina. I can't handle this, this is…. No. I can't have you on my train anymore. Call Adora. She will take over once we return to Norraryd. No, no buts! Explain the sitch, all of it! She will get it. And Glimmer, you take the railbus back, take a shower and go back home."

They both stared at Scorpia with mouths so wide open a canary could easily flewn inside.

"The next free day is Thursday. Catra, you will take the duty of fireman, next to Scorpia. Glimmer, you will be Catras trainee. You will *both* behave. *You* will show her how the ropes, for real. and *You* will listen. That is all."

"Dor…Scorpia…"

"Chairman Dröm right now. You have something to say to me, Katarina?"

"...Nothing."

"Good." She sighed. "I almost think that you should get out right now as well, Cat, but it's a bit to much to handle old 4-8 on my own. But once we get back to Norraryd Catra… You go home. And BOTH of you, think well and good about this!"

*

The ride with the railbus had been quiet for Glimmer, (even if the higher speed of the railbus had been a bit more fun) and the rest of the day had been silent. Glimmer refused to give Bow an explanation. She had take the first bus away that was possible, and once she had reached her apartment she had eaten a generous amount of Ice cream, but she had not called her mother to complain. She did respect Scorpia, and while the arrow had hit her deep, she had to admit that she had a point. Perfuma called later asking how things were. Only then did she allow herself to bawl her eyes out.

Catra had spent the rest of the day in grumbling silence, making sure to do her duty to the max. Scorpia had said nothing more, save for "Rolling!" and Adora had only shook her head when they changed position. She had not gone home though, she had instead spent the day in the shop, helping Entrapta with fixing up the troubling injector on VTJ 63, a beautiful 2-6-2 tank engine. It had been messy and required a lot of "interesting…" from Entrapta when things didn't fit as she planned. But in the end, they got it together.

She was still there as the trains returned to the sheds and she was still there when Bow found her. As he took Catra in his sweaty arms, she finally fell through and cried. Almost the whole ride back home to Växjö.

*

Thursday's service for the fireman began at eleven, with the first departure at five p.m. Catra was there well on time to get herself ready for the day. Tail and ears-care needed time and patience. Once again she found Glimmer in the crew room, wearing that same pink overalls. This time Catra didn't leave. Instead she sat down. Once seated, Glimmer produced two subs.

“Lunch?”

“...We just arrived?”

“...It’s eleven o’clock.”

Alright, alright, no bitching. Catra could recognize an olive branch when she saw one. She accepted the sub and started to eat.

“Chicken Teriyaki?”

“Mmm. Bow said it was your favourite.”

“Traitor.”

“Not Bow. He’s just doing what he thinks is best.”

“...Yeah. Bow-man is pretty awesome like that.”

“Yes. Yes he is.”

They ate in silence. Finally Catra broke it.

“Pink? Why pink?”

“I like pink. And if I can get something in pink, I will get it in pink.”

“You do realize it will get smudged, right?”

“Duh. It’s an overall. It’s made for getting smudged.”

“Oh…”

“What? You thought I would get upset if it got dirty? I *do* know some stuff about engines, okay? And besides, it can’t be that dirty.”

“Pinky…”

“GLIMMER, Catra.”

"...Maybe. I have not decided yet. Are you really sure you want to do this?"

"You are a cat."

"No shit, sherlock."

Glimmer frowned. "AND I know how hard it is to get dirt out of fur. If you can handle it, so can I."

"...How would you know?"

"I have a ex-catgirlfriend who worked as a plumber. I have seen some stuff that would chock you."

"...Who?"

"Chestnut. Know her?"

"OH GOD. She is a PURE BITCH! YOU two DATED?"

"For a few. She can be charming when she wants. But yeah, she is pretty mean. Just like someone else who maybe should be a bit more careful throwing rocks inside a glasshouse?"

Catra bit her lip.

"Alright, *Glimmer* . Let's have a mulligan." Glimmer looked up.

"You play golf?"

"For a while. It was a bit too much a good walk spoiled, but I know the basics."

Glimmer nodded. "Hard agree. Mom forced me to learn, but eh. Let's have a mulligan. Hi. You must be Catra. I am Glimmer."

"Hi Glimmer. Let's go outside and get to know our lady of today. VTJ 63, a bit different from last time, but she is kind if you treat her with respect."

After a few hours Glimmers was almost as sweaty as last time, but it was also different. They did more or less the same maneuvers as last time, with the changes that VTJ 63 was a pretty large 2-6-2 tank engine, but this time Catra bothered to *actually* explain what they were doing and why.

"I always start with cleaning the firebox, because that is the dirtiest shit so you want that done early. It helps a lot that she has drop grates, she we can just shove the slag down."

"The best way to do the lubricating is going from back to front if you ask me. It's the easiest way to remember the different spots. Now, the positions differ between engines, some need more attention to the rods, other require more on the horn blocks. This one, you see the little hole? That's where the oil goes. If you ever get up on old number 9, you will just paint the sides instead. Anyway, the best way is to do everything over, so you won't risk missing a spot when you serve another engine."

"Remember last time? Well, actually, as long as there is a little water in the boiler when you start firing them up, you're safe. The pressure will build as the heat rises and the water will get sucked inside the boiler by itself. But you have to be *sure* you see the water level. If you are the slightest bit unsure, you have to refill it by yourself."

"Coal is expensive shit. AS long as we are here, preparing, and shunting, we use wood. Wood just costs our sweat."

Glimmer nodded. This was a much better Catra.

Once Adora arrived, they drove the engine out of the shed to refill water and coal.

"Unlike the tender locomotives, This baby needs coal before every working day. We usually use a backhoe loader. So let's go fill the bucket. This will take time, and it is unpleasant. But it needs to be done."

It did take a good while, but Catra had to give it to Glimmer. She was persistent when she wanted to, and together it took them around 15 minutes to fill the bucket. Then they had to climb atop the cab roof to fill the coal bunker. That also took its merry time.

"Did they really fill the bunkers like this back in the days?"

"Well…It's not exactly historically accurate to use a backhoe loader, but… Sometimes you have to choose practicality."

"Sounds a bit like cheating."

"Back in the days none of us would have been able to work as firemen, and pink overalls was not even imaginable. What time do you prefer, Sparky?"

"...Fine."

Catra went to change clothing to a bit more uniformy look, blue pants, blueish flannel shirt and the fireman cap. She still had to have her tail bound though. "Yeah, it's not comfortable but it's this or a burnt tail."

On the footplate, five minutes to departure, Catra said "I will drive the first part. But I will explain what I do. Next round, you can give it a go. It might be scary, and it IS a lot to take in. But the best way to learn is by doing it."

Adora nodded. "Yup. That's how she taught me. She really is the best."

Glimmer looked a bit sceptical but okay… Adoras friendly smile calmed her down. … *how hard can it be?*

Oh shit this is hard! There was a lot you had to keep in mind as a fireman. When to throw in a shovel of coal, *where* to shovel…

“Even if it cools it down, you need to open the firehatch and look inside from time to time to make sure the fire burns evenly.”

Keeping an eye on the pressure. “We want it as high as we can, but if we go over twelve, the safety valves will open and then all our precious pressure will go to heck. 10 bar is good, eleven is better, so keep it somewhere around there. Also, a high pressure decreases the amount of water we consume. And that is always a good thing.”

And speaking about water… “Get the injector going anytime you can really. Keep an eye on the levels. 80% is good, and try to keep it there. Less water means less steam. More water… you get it.”

And this “blower”-thing... “Is it really called that?”

“Yes. It is silly, but that is what it does, so… Pop quiz, when do we use it?”

“While firing it up and… when shoveling the coal.”

“Correct. And why?”

“... Um…”

“Two reasons. Keeping the draught going and to make sure there's no smoke in the firebox when we open the hatch so we can see where to put the coal.”

And so it went on. Glimmer had to admit that while Catra could be a bit too serious for her taste from time to time, she really *loved* doing this and that passion was slowly crossing over to Glimmer. And she *had* really taken the time to explain exactly what a hole in the fire was, and how to look for it. “At worst, it’s like a black spot, but you should never let it go that far. It’s more of a feeling, the absence of flames really. Here, have a look!” And maybe a little more… Glimmer did her best to listen of course but more often than not she found herself lost looking at Catra. She was almost… beautiful where she stood in front of the firebox, her face

lit with the flames and her experienced eyes looking over the fire. And seeing her eyes glow with excitement as Adora gave full throttle so they could hear the engine work hard on the slopes as they neared Kvarnamåla… Not to mention how the drops of sweat made Catras face shimmer in a certain way… Glimmer had to bite her lip. She was not that kind of u-haul, sexcrazed bisexual who fell for the first beautiful girl she saw.

Even if she *had* a lot of pros… Not to mention that Catra wasn't exactly the *first* beautiful girl she saw there…

*

Glimmer's first attempt on her own at being at the helm went… pretty bad, but honestly, that was kinda what Catra had hoped. If the first time goes too well, you get too cocky and then the lady will show you all her wrath. But this time Catra helped her and they managed to get all the way to Tingsryd and back. Catra had to say one thing for Glimmer, she did not hold back. She went all in, and when Catra had adjusted her, she doubled down to do it righter the next time. The way her hair and eyes shimmered in the light of the fire… And that cute little frown when things didn't go as she planned… Glimmer was actually really beautiful. When she was angry she was beautiful, (In hindsight, Catra had to admit that) but when she laughed that doubled. And boy did she laugh… When Adora decided to really show what 63 could do in the last ascension towards Kvarnamåla… Glimmer laughed like crazy and Catra felt her fur rise a little. *Herregud alltså…*

With the engine well back in the shed and all three women back in the changing room Adora said "Well, I for one think you have what it takes, Glimmer. What do you say, Catra?"

Catra, who had been trying her best *not* to ogle Glimmer as she tried to worm her naked, sweaty body out of her overalls, didn't hear her at first. And once she did…

"Um…uh… yeah… I mean!" She added once she finally caught up, "there *might* be potential. But she will need a few more rounds on

the plate.”

Glimmer pouted as she went into the shower, as Adora nodded. “Oh, definitely. Would you mind having her with you next Tuesday? It's probably good that she learns the basics before she goes with me or Scorpia, don’t you think?”

Again, Catra had looked anywhere but the showers. “Uh? Oh sure! Sure! Sure!”

When the Kvarnamåla incident had happened, it felt like Scorpia had decided never to talk to Catra again but after a few weeks things seemed to be back to normal. The first thing she said to Catra was “So, have you guys kissed yet?”

Catra was handfallen and could do nothing but stare at Scorpia for a few minutes.

“Kissed? What do you…”

“Oh come on wildcat! The tension between the two of you was thick as cylinder oil! I could tell from miles apart that Glimmer was interested. And I knew *you* were.”

“And how the hell do you know that? She annoyed the shit out of me!”

“Everytime someone annoys you, it usually ends up with you declaring how beautiful they are, especially if you have a beer first.”

“HOW DO YOU… That is so not true!”

“Oh, are you calling Bow a liar?”

“THAT LITTLE…”

“Now now Catra. He just feels the need to get things out in the open when it’s necessary. Anyway, have you?”

“NO! As a matter of fact, both of you are wrong! …She is cute, and she is improving. B-but there is nothing between us! Nothing! I am as single as I can be! As I want to be!”

Scorpia whistled innocently. “Alright… If you say so. Anyway, it’s time to fire up the old tie-placer! We need to get at least ten sticks in the ground before the next day of traffic!”

And so they worked, in silence. Catra couldn’t decide if it had been good or bad that Scorpia talked to her again.

And there was NOTHING between her and Glimmer. Just professional relations.

But as summer passed, for anyone who followed the lists, a few rather interesting things could be noted. If Catra had signed up for working as the fireman, Glimmer's

 name as trainee had a tendency to follow…and if Glimmer had signed up as a trainee, Catra either signed herself up as a fireman soon after, or switched places. More than often they shared a car to Norraryd, and there had been a scramble to get Pizza, they always volunteered to get it. And they always shared. Pepperoni, Tuna and mushrooms.

Around the end of july, Glimmer realized that she and Catra had gone on three dates without knowing. Like when they had coffee at Broqvists Patiserrie, Glimmer could have asked bow, but she knew Catra had the day off work so… Or when Entrapta and Catra had repaired the old trolley and asked if Glimmer wanted to tag along to try it… That took most of the day, since they HAD to stop for lunch at Urshult… And Tingsryd. And Urshult again. And when they both wanted to see the Barbie-movie and by *pure accident* (not like they called and made sure the other would be at the cinema) went to the same viewing…

When Glimmer actually asked Catra out for real, Catra panicked. She was going to ask first….

The first time they kissed was on July the 29th, when Glimmer had managed to do the whole service herself, from beginning to end. Glimmer tasted like cool, sweat, oil and cotton candy and one kiss soon became five. And the day Glimmer was examined (by Scorpia) was the day Catra asked her to move in with her.

"I mean… you are cute and so, but you're also pretty annoying. I just need some help with the rent, that's all."

"And you like my boobs."

"I have never noticed them before."

"Your tail says something else."

" *Traitor!"*

One year later, Catra did her first service as a driver on her own. Three guessed who volunteered to be fireman. Glimmer was not allowed the pink overall, that was a bit too much even for Scorpia. That had to be a dark blue one. How she found a plaid-patterned *pink* flannel shirt to go with it though was a riddle for everyone, but found one she did and she wore it with pride. Catra had grunted, but in secret, she smiled. Pink was exactly the right color for her favourite fireman.

Fully dressed and ready, they stood on the footplate of old 4-8.

They shared a kiss, but just as Catra was ready to push the throttle Glimmer said "I am so happy I could throw up."

"Please don't, you have to clean yourself, and why?"

"Standing here. On my favorite engine. With my favourite driver. Doing what I love the most."

“Save for eating candy and binge watch Anime”

“HA! I know you watch them when I’m not home!”

“...I need to learn to clean my search history.”

"Yes, you do.” She paused. “Do you think she did this on purpose?”

“What?”

“Adora. You know, I asked to go with her at first.”

“Oh. Why?”

“Well… this is going to sound silly but… I had the biggest crush on her.”

“....Oh.”

“Yeah… I wanted to be there with her, you know…”

“Mmmm.. I can imagine.”

“But then I met you. And you were everything Adora wasn’t.” She paused. “I think I fell for you the second you screamed at me.”

“What the f, Pinkie?”

“Yeah… I know… But there was something. You were.. You were real. Adora feels… too good to be true. But you? 100% Catra, top to bottom. I don’t think you can be anything but yourself.”

Catra didn’t blush. “So… Shall we take her out for a spin?”

Glimmer saluted Catra. “Aye aye boss! Pressure is 9.7 bars and rising, we have plenty of water and I brought some waffles for the break.”

Catra smiled. It had been a beautiful morning in the engine shed at Norraryd. The view over the Hönshylte Fiord was beautiful as

the rays of the rising sun lit it up from top to bottom. The stillness of the morning was giving in to the sounds of the day, and a stem engine is never discreet, but it was still rather quiet and still. Only a few birds could be heard and they had seen a row of ducks passing over the road heading for the Hönshylte Meer. Yes, it should be a great day!

End Notes

The words in swedish are mostly swearwords, but there is a few others.
"Gomorron" is 'morning!'
"Det vet du" means "You know it!"
Dröm is Dream, as in Linda D'ream.
The rest is not safe for woona.

In case you are a fellow railway entusiast and feel the urge to go look this railway up, I am afraid that is of no avail. The railway is just a place in my mind, althought the names and engines are real, and there HAS been a railway between those towns... Once... Many years ago. So this is my dream railway with my dream girls working on it. I hope you enjoyed it, it was fun to write.

I hope I got most of the technical details right, if I didn't, just accept it. It's nerdy as it is.

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